

ROOM TONE

a short film

Blue Sheep Films

working draft v1.1

INT. GUITAR SHOP - BACK ROOM - NIGHT

A workbench under one good lamp. Solder smoke. Pedals with their guts out. NOAH (26) reflows a joint with the patience of a monk and the posture of a question mark.

Through the doorway, the dark shop floor: hanging guitars, price tags turning slowly in the furnace air.

GLEN (50s), the owner, backs in carrying a milk crate of gear. Drops it on the bench. Dust jumps.

GLEN
Storage auction. Lot forty-four.
Test what works, wipe what
remembers, tag it all by Friday.

NOAH
Wipe what remembers?

GLEN
Phones, loopers, anything with a
memory. People leave their whole
lives on these. Policy.

Glen leaves. Noah lifts the crate's top layer – cables like nesting snakes – and underneath, a TASCAM 4-TRACK, corners worn white, one fader capped with a pencil eraser.

He turns it over. Battery bay: corroded. He looks at it the way some people look at rescue dogs.

There's a cassette still in the deck.

Handwritten label, faded: apr – 4.

MAIN TITLE: ROOM TONE

INT. GUITAR SHOP - BACK ROOM - LATER

New batteries. Headphones the size of soup bowls. Noah hesitates – some doors you don't knock on – then presses PLAY.

Tape hiss, warm as weather. Then: a WOMAN'S VOICE, close to the mic, double-tracked with itself a hair apart. A guitar that was never tuned to anything but itself. The song is half-finished and completely alive.

Noah stops soldering. Stops everything.

The song climbs toward a bridge – reaches for it – and a PHONE RINGS in the recording, far off, another room, another year. The voice laughs, says something off-mic –

WOMAN (ON TAPE)
(faint, to somebody)
— it's still going —

CLICK. Hiss. Nothing.

Noah sits in the nothing for a long time. Rewinds. Plays the climb again. It never resolves. It never gets to.

INT. NOAH'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

A mattress, a lamp on the floor, a good guitar in a room that owns nothing else worth stealing. Rain against the window like static.

Noah, cross-legged, headphones on, the 4-track on a milk crate. He plays the song for the fourth time. Fifth time.

He picks up his guitar and hunts for her chords in the dark — finds the first one — loses the second. Her tuning isn't a tuning. It's a decision.

He plays along anyway, quietly, a beat behind her, the way you walk with someone whose stride you don't share yet.

INT. NOAH'S APARTMENT - LATER

He flips the cassette. Side B. Presses PLAY, expecting nothing.

Not nothing.

Forty minutes of a room. Dishes somewhere. A kettle. Rain — different rain, older rain. A chair creaks. Far off, in another room, somebody laughs at something we'll never know. Nobody performs anything. Nobody says anything to the mic.

Somebody just recorded their apartment. On purpose. To keep it.

Noah lies back on the mattress, headphones on, eyes open, and listens to a stranger's Tuesday from years ago like it's a symphony.

The tape rolls. His own rain and her old rain, both going at once.

INT. GUITAR SHOP - BACK ROOM - DAY

Glen inventories. Noah, casual as a heart attack:

NOAH
The four-track from lot forty-four.
I'll buy it. Staff price.

GLEN
It's junk. Battery bay's gone
green.

NOAH
Staff price, then.

GLEN
(not looking up)
Wipe the tape first. Policy.

A beat. Noah looks at the shelf where the cassette isn't,
because it's been in his jacket pocket for two days.

NOAH
Obviously.

INT. STOR-ALL SELF STORAGE - OFFICE - DAY

Fluorescents. A DESK GUY (40s) behind plexiglass, a fan
pushing warm air around. Noah at the counter with the
cassette case.

NOAH
Lot forty-four. The unit it came
from. I'm trying to find the
person.

DESK GUY
Unit one-eighteen. Lapsed. We send
three letters, then it goes to
auction. That's the process.

NOAH
Three letters.

DESK GUY
Certified. Very fair.
(beat; almost human)
You'd be surprised how many people
get all three and just... let it
go. Cheaper than deciding.

He slides the case back under the plexiglass.

DESK GUY (CONT'D)
Can't give you a name. Privacy.

But Noah's already looking at the case in his hand – inside
the J-card, folded small, a photocopied FLYER. A band name.
A basement address. A date twelve years old.

NOAH
Don't need one.

INT. PLANT SHOP - DAY

Ferns like green weather. And there – watering them, hair tied up with a pencil, ten years older than her voice – EVIE (30s).

Noah stands among the plants holding a cassette like it's a warrant he's embarrassed about. She clocks him. Waits.

NOAH
I fix gear at a shop across town. A four-track came through from a storage auction.

He holds up the tape. apr – 4.

She goes still. Not upset-still. Archaeological-still.

EVIE
Huh.

NOAH
I wasn't going to wipe it. They have a policy. I have a different one.

She dries her hands. Takes the tape. Turns it over once, like checking a fruit for bruises.

EVIE
April. God. I was twenty-two.

NOAH
The song –

EVIE
The bridge never resolves.

NOAH
I know. I've been trying to play it for a week.

EVIE
Why? It's broken.

NOAH
It isn't finished. That's different.

She looks at him then – properly, the way you look at somebody who has accidentally said something true about you in a plant shop on a Tuesday.

EVIE
You came all the way here to give a
stranger her homework back.

NOAH
I came all the way here because
somebody should get to decide,
and it isn't the storage company,
and it isn't me.

A long moment. Ferns breathing. Then she hands the tape
BACK to him.

EVIE
Keep the song. Finish it, wipe it,
marry it. It stopped being mine
when I stopped reaching for it.

Noah takes it. Doesn't know what to do with his hands. She
turns back to her watering – then stops.

EVIE (CONT'D)
Wait. Is Side B still –

NOAH
The room? Yeah. All of it.

Everything about her changes. Small, seismic.

EVIE
That was our kitchen on Fourth. The
laugh at the end – you can hear a
laugh?

NOAH
Around minute thirty. Another room.

EVIE
(quiet)
That's my sister. She lives in
Perth now.

She holds out her hand. He gives the tape back. This time
she takes it like it's warm.

EVIE (CONT'D)
You can have the song. Come by, dub
it off, whatever. But the room's
mine.

NOAH
The room's yours.

He leaves her holding twelve years in a plastic shell,
standing in the ferns.

INT. NOAH'S APARTMENT - EVENING

Golden hour doing its one trick through the window. The
4-track on the milk crate, battery bay scrubbed clean.

Noah doesn't play the song. He doesn't play anything.

He loads a BLANK TAPE. Sets the mic on the crate, pointed at
nothing – at the window, the radiator, the middle of the
room. Presses RECORD. The reels turn.

Then he gets up and does the dishes.

Water running. A plate against a plate. Rain starting up
outside, brand new. Somewhere down the hall, a neighbour's
TV laughs at something we'll never know.

The tape rolls, keeping all of it.

CUT TO BLACK.

Over black, tape hiss – and the first chord of an
unresolved bridge, resolving into

THE END